

Recreating Da Vinci

Scientists in Florence, Italy, successfully created a working model of Da Vinci's automobile in April 2004

DB5

The first DB5 prototype used in 'Goldfinger' was later stripped of its weaponry and gadgetry by Aston Martin

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The self-propelled vehicle – or automobile – has come a long way since Karl Benz first patented his 'horseless carriage' in 1885. Simply attaching a motor to a wheel has, since then, led to an altering of our perception of time and space and creating, among other things, cities, suburbs and growth of an international motoring community.

With the use of artificial intelligence, new design technology and innovations in materials, scientists, entrepreneurs and researchers from different parts of the world are striving to create new and improved vehicles that can be used by

the masses. In the 21st century, then, perhaps we are on the threshold of seeing Hollywood fantasy cars turn into fact. It is quite possible that we may soon have to change our definition of the 'car' as we know it. Let's take you through some of the most interesting advances in automobiles that are likely to change the way we commute in the not-so-distant future.

Beyond the road

Roads were made to enable automobiles to travel quickly between distant settlements. Over the last few decades, much effort has been put in to literally, 'getting the show off the road' for automobiles. New automotive Research and Development seems to hint that the road might soon become just a point of access to

another mode of transportation for your car – air, or even water.

Cars on the wing

Several attempts to fuse an aircraft with a car have been made throughout history. The Hovercraft – a car that runs on a cushion of air – was once much-touted by science fiction writers like Arthur C. Clarke, but was eventually proved impractical due to the high level of noise and fuel consumption. The Aerocar by Moulton Taylor in the 1950s was made of wings, a tail and a power plant – a single engine that powered the road wheels as well as the propeller. Henry Smolinski's 'Mizar' was built in the 1970s by Advanced Vehicle Engineers (AVE) by fitting together the rear part of a Cessna

The Motor Marvels

Recent R&D in automotive technology is literally *getting the show off the road*